

COSMIC ARK TERRA
(WORKING TITLE, I STILL NEED A BETTER ONE)

Written by

John Cheek

INT. COSMIC ARK TERRA ATRIUM - SUNSET

A group of people walk with a sense of urgency through an earth-like environment with beautiful vistas of forests, rivers, lakes, and small mountains in the distance.

Other people can be seen watching them pass by and acknowledge them with reverence. It is clear that they are figures of high status.

We move in on CAPTAIN ELIA SEPH, a woman in her late 30s dressed in a decorated white captain's uniform with a dark green cloak, at the center of this group accompanied by her second in command, COMMANDER CORWIN, COMMUNICATIONS OFFICER SMITH, as well as a number of her ADVISORS.

COMM. OFFICER SMITH

Have you received the agenda for this council session ma'am?

CAPTAIN SEPH

Well as the new communications officer, I figured that might have been your responsibility.

COMM. OFFICER SMITH

Well, I had just gotten back from the Saturn and this session was called so suddenly I--

CAPTAIN SEPH

With this being an emergency session Admiral Morros would make more of an effort to inform us of the agenda, but it would appear not.

COMM. OFFICER SMITH

So do you have any idea what it may be about?

CAPTAIN SEPH

Well, the last one was due to a solar flare in a nearby system that took out the Mercury's long range navigation array, but that was back when Captain Almec was in command.

COMM. OFFICER SMITH

And could this session be something like that?

CAPTAIN SEPH

No, if it was a solar flare everyone in the fleet would know by now. What are they teaching over on the Saturn, you really ought to know these things.

COMM. OFFICER SMITH looks away towards a tablet, embarrassed. SEPH smiles, she's just giving him a hard time. She shifts her attention towards COMMANDER CORWIN.

CAPTAIN SEPH (CONT'D)

Is the transport ready?

COMMANDER CORWIN

Yes ma'am, it's just waiting for us, and we're already running late so it would be best to pick up the pace. We would have been there by now if we had just taken the lift down to the hanger.

CAPTAIN SEPH

If Marros could have done me the decency of providing a reason for this session it would be different. The council meeting can't start until all members are present. Besides-- haven't you enjoyed taking the scenic route?

COMMANDER CORWIN shakes his head as the group keeps walking. CAPTAIN SEPH walks with purpose, but she still takes her time to appreciate the environment and the people in it.

We see a family walking through a garden together, young kids climbing a tree, some older teenagers playing in a stream. Those that see SEPH stop whatever they're doing and some give a respectful bow, while others a timid wave.

Eventually she sees KELDAN: 20s male from the Cosmic Ark Venus, down on his knee next to AVERY: 20s female. They are at some picturesque natural location with the sun setting on the horizon over a roaring waterfall. It is clear KELDAN is proposing. SEPH holds up her hand to stop. They watch from afar as the couple celebrates. After a time, SEPH approaches, rather excitedly.

CAPTAIN SEPH (CONT'D)

Let me be the first to offer my congratulations.

KELDAN and AVERY are a bit awestruck, KELDAN more so than AVERY. It's not every day a Captain of a Cosmic Ark approaches you. They each give a shallow bow, then KELDAN takes another moment to collect himself, a bit unsure of what to do.

KELDAN

What an honor to meet you ma'am.
Keldan, Cosmic Ark Venus, and this
is my par- well I suppose fiancé,
Avery, also from Venus.

KELDAN extends his hand for SEPH to shake. She does so. Same with Avery.

CAPTAIN SEPH

Captain Elia Seph, Cosmic Ark
Terra.

COMMANDER CORWIN approaches from off screen, tapping SEPH on her shoulder and whispering in her ear.

COMMANDER CORWIN

We really should be going ma'am.

CAPTAIN SEPH

In a moment, COMMANDER CORWIN.

COMMANDER CORWIN reluctantly steps away. SEPH shifts her attention back to KELDAN.

CAPTAIN SEPH (CONT'D)

That you would choose the Terra for
such an important moment, the honor
is mine Keldan.

KELDAN

There's no other place like it
ma'am. Avery and I come here every
day we have off, it's a welcome
break from everything back home on
Venus.

AVERY

The crowds can be a bit much to
bare and the noise-- you're very
lucky to be one of the few who live
on Terra.

CAPTAIN SEPH

Getting to wake up to these skies
every day is a luxury I wish we all
could appreciate, and we will one
day.

There is a pause. SEPH smiles, the other two seem hesitant.

CAPTAIN SEPH (CONT'D)
Even if not us, than perhaps your
children? Nevertheless, I'm glad
these skies are here for us for
moments like yours. I wish you both
the best.

SEPH smiles again, they smile back, then SEPH returns to her advisors and they continue walking.

We zoom out on SEPH and her company. The final artifacts of dusk fade and a night sky emerges. There is a shimmer of blue light across the sky as it warps in a hexagonal pattern and fades.

In it's place we see a sky full of stars but instead of a moon or any constellations we would expect to see, we instead see eight large spacecraft orbiting a somewhat smaller, ship: the Cosmic Ark Sol.

EXT. COSMIC ARK TERRA - OUTER SPACE

A massive spacecraft shaped almost like a turtle. The 'shell' is a massive pristine glass dome beneath which we can see an expansive earth like environment.

A smaller spacecraft we see is named Terra One travels from below the dome off screen.

EXT. COSMIC ARK SOL - OUTER SPACE

A bronze spaceship with many ornate decorations and windows drifts through outer space. It is beautiful, but shows many signs of age.

Additionally we see the eight other Cosmic Arks, all clearly built for function rather than form. They show similar signs of wear.

INT. TERRA ONE - OUTER SPACE

CAPTAIN SEPH looks in a mirror. She adjusts and straightens her uniform but never seems fully content with it. We hear indistinct chatter in the background between SOL OFFICER and COMMANDER CORWIN.

SOL OFFICER (O.S.)
Domum quaerens, Humanitas ut una.

COMMANDER CORWIN (O.S.)
Humanitas ut una.

A BEEP, like a phone hanging up. Seph is more aware of her surroundings

COMMANDER CORWIN (CONT'D)
We'll be docking shortly captain.

CAPTAIN SEPH
Still no word from Sol about the reasoning for this session?

COMMANDER CORWIN
No ma'am

SEPH grows more anxious, something about this session is troubling her.

INT. COSMIC ARK SOL HANGAR - OUTER SPACE

SEPH exits her ship into an elegant hanger, almost like a fancy car garage. Similar ones can be seen in the hangar. We see ones labeled Neptune One, Mars One, and Pluto One.

CAPTAIN ISOBEL WINTER is standing by Pluto One, having just exited her ship. She wears a similar white captains outfit to SEPH but wears a black cloak.

She sees CAPTAIN SEPH and approaches her, SEPH smiles upon her friend but it doesn't hold for long. They both are on edge.

CAPTAIN SEPH
Isobel, do you have any idea of Marros's reason for this session?

CAPTAIN WINTER
No, I was hoping you would.

SEPH shakes her head.

CAPTAIN SEPH
I'm as in the dark as you, and the rest of the fleet it seems.

CAPTAIN WINTER
Marros has never given much information about the agenda for any council session, but it is very troubling to hear nothing.

INT. COSMIC ARK SOL CORRIDORS - OUTER SPACE

SEPH and WINTER begin walking and conversing through the corridors of the Sol, heading to the main council chambers. Any personal who see them bow their heads as they walk past. They walk with purpose, but not haste.

CAPTAIN SEPH

I feel like I haven't seen you
since the last meeting.

CAPTAIN WINTER

Because you haven't, I keep telling
you to visit Pluto, guess I'm not
convincing enough?

CAPTAIN SEPH

I don't think anyone in the history
of this fleet has *wanted* to visit
Pluto.

This joke mildly irritates WINTER. In any other situation she would appreciate it, but they are both on edge.

CAPTAIN WINTER

Pluto's role in this fleet is as
important as that of any Cosmic
Ark. It reminds us of those who
gave their lives to carry us this
far. To remember-- just like Terra.

There is a pause, SEPH's tone shifts.

CAPTAIN SEPH

How are things on Pluto?

CAPTAIN WINTER

Difficult, to say the least.

CAPTAIN SEPH

How do you mean?

CAPTAIN WINTER

We've seen more and more pleading
to enter stasis. They claim their
family has spent generations aboard
the Arks and yet we're nowhere
closer to our destination. I don't
particularly blame the for it, I
empathize with them even.

CAPTAIN SEPH

But that's not the hard part is it.

CAPTAIN WINTER

No. Marros's moratorium on voluntary statis either seems to not have reached them or they believe they are an exception, and when I tell them they can't--

CAPTAIN SEPH

--they tend to take the other way out.

WINTER nods.

CAPTAIN SEPH (CONT'D)

Let me know if there's any way Terra can help.

CAPTAIN WINTER

Thank you. We're managing for now, but I'll reach out if anything comes up.

CAPTAIN SEPH

Terra has a way of grounding people, don't hesitate to send them our way. And please visit yourself if you have the time, you're always welcome.

CAPTAIN WINTER

I miss our time together at the academy on Saturn. Council sessions need to stop being the only time we see each other.

They pause. SEPH smiles at WINTER. The intensity of the situation seems to fade a bit, they now are just talking as friends.

CAPTAIN WINTER (CONT'D)

How are Abi and Damien?

CAPTAIN SEPH

Damien has been very busy with maintenance projects throughout Terra's atrium, everything just seems to be falling apart lately, but Abi has been enjoying visiting many different parts of the Terra with her father before she starts going to Saturn for school.

CAPTAIN WINTER
Abi is academy age already?

CAPTAIN SEPH
I can't believe it either, she
starts in two months.

CAPTAIN WINTER
Well, she has her father's
curiosity and her mother's
stubbornness, she'll be a great
student.

SEPH smiles and chuckles a bit.

CAPTAIN SEPH
That she will.

They approach an ornate door marked with the Symbol of the Cosmic Ark Terra guarded by two figures in white military uniforms with golden cloaks. Seph takes a deep breath.

Before Seph she walks into her booth, she turns to Captain Winter.

CAPTAIN SEPH (CONT'D)
I missed you Isobel.

CAPTAIN WINTER
I missed you too Elia, good luck in
there.

Seph exits, Captain Winter stands outside the door and collects herself for a moment before proceeding down the hallway.

INT. COMMERCIAL TRANSPORT VESSEL - OUTER SPACE

We see AVERY looking out a window in space. We can see he is looking at the exterior of the Cosmic Ark Terra in the distance.

KELDAN and AVERY sit in what is essentially a space bus. Lots of people are densely packed together in cramped rows of seats. Keldan stares at a tablet screen in front of him. We hear a DING as an announcement plays.

TRANSPORT P.A (V.O.)
Thank you for using the Inter-ark
Transport Network aboard Transport
1208. We are now approaching our
next destination: Cosmic Ark Venus.

Avery turns her attention from the window towards Keldan.

AVERY
I wish we could have stayed on
Terra longer.

KELDAN
Me too. I'm sorry, I told them I
was out today.

INSERT - TABLET SCREEN

There is a 3D cube shape of a large apartment block. Many sections of it are lit up red. More sections begin to illuminate with a popup next to them reading 'OVERSEER ASSISTANCE REQUESTED'

BACK TO SCENE

AVERY
Guess everyone always needs
something from the greatest block
overseer on Venus.

KELDAN
Well I certainly wish I had the pay
to back that up, but it isn't that,
everyone is on edge about the
emergency session today.

Avery's demeanor shifts, this is news to her.

AVERY
I didn't know there was one today.

KELDAN
Marros called it this morning while
we were on Terra. I didn't want to
tell you, I know we had this visit
planned for a long time.

AVERY
Oh-- thank you.

KELDAN
I didn't think it would altar our
plans, but everyone seems so on
edge about it, I figured I should
be back home to help.

AVERY
Considering what you had to go
through when Marros enacted the
statis moratorium, I understand.

Keldan freezes up. Avery puts her hand on Keldan's shoulder to comfort him.

KELDAN

That day was filled with difficult conversations, and that was just a regularly scheduled session, I hope today won't be anything like that. You see why I want to be home for this one.

AVERY

I do. But listen to me, regardless of what it is, you'll help our neighbors through it, you always do.

KELDAN

Time's are getting harder, we've been drifting for so long. I can't help but feel like there will be more days like that to come.

AVERY

Love, you're the most respected Overseer on Venus. You helped them then, and you'll help them now.

Keldan smiles, and relaxes a little bit. He lays his head on Avery's shoulder.

KELDAN

I'm so excited to marry you.

INT. COSMIC ARK SOL COUNCIL CHAMBER - OUTER SPACE

We follow CAPTAIN SEPH as the doors slide open entering the council chamber.

Inside we see a circular golden table with 10 seats around it, and a taller seat at the far end. All other CAPTAINS of the Cosmic Arks are present as well as ADMIRAL MARROS wearing a white decorated admirals outfit with a golden cloak and other golden ornaments.

CAPTAIN WINTER enters shortly after and sits at the council table where each CAPTAIN of the Cosmic Arks are seated. In the chamber, beyond the council table, about 50 officers in military uniforms with different colored cloaks are also present.

There is chaos within the chamber. Voices clamor over each other both from the observers and the CAPTAINS. SEPH and WINTER silently look at each other from across the table.

Suddenly, ADMIRAL MARROS's voice booms.

ADMIRAL MARROS
Domum quaerens, Humanitas ut una.

ALL
Humanitas ut una.

Silence falls over the chamber.

ADMIRAL MARROS
For over a thousand years, the Arks
have carried humanity across the
cosmos. They have served both as
our home and the engine that drives
us forward to a new home-- ever
since our first one was lost.

He pauses.

ADMIRAL MARROS (CONT'D)
Now we stand twenty million strong,
with a million more waiting in
statis aboard Pluto-- all relying
on us to complete our mission, the
same one they set out upon a
millennia ago.

MARROS gestures towards WINTER, we see a nameplate before her that reads CAPTAIN WINTER.

ADMIRAL MARROS (CONT'D)
To this date, in the one-thousand ,
one hundred and seventeenth year of
our mission, we have visited one
hundred and thirty potentially
habitable planets.

With a wave of his hand, the circular space all around the council table illuminates with a holographic model of 137 planets floating in space, there is a pause. The planets float in the sky throughout the whole grand chamber, and above the council members.

With another wave of his hand, all 137 planets illuminate bright red. There is a silence in the chamber. Marros lets this moment linger before making a fist and pulling his arm in, as the image dissipates.

ADMIRAL MARROS (CONT'D)
And not one of them has proved a
suitable home for us.

A long pause, that sinks in.

ADMIRAL MARROS (CONT'D)
I know you all are wondering why I
called this session. To put it
plainly, we are running out of
time. I now yield to Captain Farren
of the Cosmic Ark Mercury to share
the results of his latest scouting
report.

ADMIRAL MARROS's seat recedes to the same level as the rest
of the council but still a little bit higher. CAPTAIN
FARREN's seat raises as a light shines on him. He wears
another white captains uniform with an orange cloak.

CAPTAIN FARREN
As the Admiral noted, we have just
returned from an extended scouting
mission. On our generational
horizon of around 80 light years,
we have only identified three
potentially habitable planets--

Now, Captain Farren waves his hand as the holographic
projection within the chamber appears again, this time with
the 10 cosmic arks in a small scale at the center, and a
distinct circular ring around them. There are many planets
within this ring, but only three of them are lit up green.
There is a zig-zag sort of pattern from the center, then
bounding between the three planets.

CAPTAIN FARREN (CONT'D)
Each with only a two percent or
less chance of providing an earth-
like environment.

Silence, a long pause. Everyone in the chamber is dreading
Farren's next words.

CAPTAIN FARREN (CONT'D)
When the Last Terrans built the
Arks, they truly had no idea how
long they would last. All they knew
was that they would last long
enough to find a home. This
however, has not been the case.

Another pause, complete silence.

CAPTAIN FARREN (CONT'D)
 Our calculations predict, and
 Saturn has verified- that the Arks
 can only operate at our current
 rate for another century.

Shouting erupts throughout the chamber. Some other captains
 engage in the discourse. SEPH is silent, but mortified. We
 see her processing as the voices get drowned out.

ADMIRAL MARROS
 Ad domum nostram, humanitatem ut
 unam

Still commotion, SEPH is still silent.

ADMIRAL MARROS (CONT'D)
 (Louder, more
 authoritative)
**ad domum nostram, humanitatem ut
 unam**

ALL
 humanitatem ut unam

ADMIRAL MARROS
 Thank you. I know how troubling
 this is. Rest assured we considered
 every angle before unveiling this
 information to you all, but we
 wouldn't come to you without a
 solution. I again yield to Captain
 Farren so that he may continue.

CAPTAIN FARREN
 Thank you Admiral. As I was saying,
 our fleet can continue to operate,
 for about one generational horizon.
 In this range, there is a very low
 chance of finding a suitable home.

More shouting and overlapping voices

CAPTAIN FARREN (CONT'D)
 However, we have identified a
 system, about 287 light years away,
 with a potentially habitable
 planet. We must get closer to run
 more tests but as of now, this
 planet has a 42 percent likelihood
 of providing us a suitable home.

The chamber goes dark and a large crude hologram of an earth like planet appears in the center. Everyone in the chamber has given up any arguing and are now listening intently.

CAPTAIN FARREN (CONT'D)

Even given the measures we have already taken to prolong our journey, we lack the resources to reach this system-- or even get close enough to make more concrete observations. I know this is disheartening, which is why we come before you today with this plan, I again yield to the Admiral.

ADMIRAL MARROS

We have already enforced rationing, reduced the operational capacity of many non-essential services, and restricted travel between Arks while maintaining a consistent travel speed.

MARROS attention shifts towards SEPH.

ADMIRAL MARROS (CONT'D)

The Cosmic Ark Terra houses none other than Captain Elia Seph and her counsel, while it consumes the most oxygen, recyclable waste, and the highest amount of water, second only to Neptune, where it is essential for food production.

SEPH clenches her fists, trying to bite her tongue

ADMIRAL MARROS (CONT'D)

Yet it's role is hard to place. Each ark serves it's distinct purpose-- except Terra which serves as nothing but a relic of a bygone era.

He breaks his attention away from SEPH, focusing instead on the council chamber audience. SEPH and WINTER look at each other, WINTER mouths "Don't"

ADMIRAL MARROS (CONTD) (CONT'D)

Which is why we propose a solution to our plight. We can prolong the fleet's journey for 300 years, guaranteeing our chance to arrive at our new home-- if we decommission and salvage the Cosmic Ark Terra.

The chamber erupts, some shout in outrage, others in claps of approval. SEPH stands in disbelief, slamming both her hands onto the table before shouting. The anger boiling inside of her wells to the surface

CAPTAIN SEPH
Absolutely not.

ADMIRAL MARROS
Ad domum nostram, humanitatem ut
unam.

The chamber quiets down. SEPH still stands.

ADMIRAL MARROS (CONT'D)
Those are the words the lat Terrans spoke before leaving everything behind. Towards our home, humanity as one. They also bring order to this chamber-- in case you have forgotten.

He turns his attention back to the chamber.

ADMIRAL MARROS (CONT'D)
We have explored many possible solutions, yet this continuously presents itself as the most optimal. Now, as I understand the nature of this matter, I will yield to you Captain Seph.

CAPTAIN SEPH
It is appreciated, Admiral.
However, I must ask *who* made this decision and why weren't I- or any other council members besides Captain Farren present when making this decision? Do you feel your station gives you power to jeopardize my ship. I urge you, all of you, to reconsider what this means for our fleet.

ADMIRAL MARROS
This proposal was drafted in collaboration with scientists on mercury, as well as assistance with scholars aboard Saturn. A proposal can be made and brought forth by anyone.

CAPTAIN SEPH

Damn your proposal. How are we even to trust anything that happens behind closed doors on Sol?

ADMIRAL MARROS

I understand your concern, and I'm sure there are many others who share it, which is why we will address any concerns from any of the Arks once the session has concluded as long as they follow the proper channels.

SEPH is silent, looking first to CAPTAIN WINTER, than to anyone to support. Some share looks of empathy, others hope, but they are all as speechless as she is.

ADMIRAL MARROS (CONT'D)

Furthermore, you have my guarantee that this proposal will go through the proper process. At next month's regularly scheduled meeting, we will reconvene and the ten Arks will vote. With that, this emergency session is adjourned. Ad domum nostram, humanitatem ut unam.

More shouting, even more chaos in the chamber, ADMIRAL MARROS looks away as his podium descends and he exits the chamber. He is swarmed by people with questions but addresses none and exits. We see SEPH sitting in her seat deflated, holding back tears, but trying to think of a plan.

INT. KELDAN'S QUARTERS, COSMIC ARK VENUS - OUTER SPACE

The space barely looks like enough room to comfortably house 4 people. The furniture is sterile and worn, but there are touches of decoration to make the space more inviting. There is one small window looking into outer space.

KELDAN and AVERY sit speechless, watching the emergency session conclude on a monitor.

KELDAN

How the hell does Marros think he can get that through, salvage an entire Ark? Terra no less? It's asinine.

AVERY

I don't know. I don't agree with it, but it would give us a better shot at getting through this.

KELDAN

Us? We'll be dead long before we get there.

AVERY

Don't say that. Remember what Captain Seph said? We don't do this for us. We do this for the ones that come after, and they would have a better chance at making it if the proposal goes through.

KELDAN

Do you seriously think the fabled planet Captain Farren mentioned is real? That it really could be the home we've been searching so long for? It's three hundred years away, for all we know it could just be a speck of dust on the scanner. No- it's just another worthless rock.

AVERY

It could be.

KELDAN

I don't want to bring a child into this world Avery- I can't do that to them.

KELDAN is on the verge of tears. He looks at Avery

KELDAN (CONT'D)

I don't want our children to live in a world that's just this shitty excuse for a home, they deserve more than that. They deserve trees, and mountains, and rivers, and likes, and to live under a sky- even if it is simulated.

He breaks down, she puts his hand on his.

KELDAN (CONT'D)

It's not enough for them to survive, I want them to live. Just like we did, and just like all those before us did.

They embrace, she has a hesitant look on her face, but then it fades.

AVERY

I don't want that either.

There is commotion in the hallways outside. KELDAN and AVERY go outside to check.

INT. RESIDENCE BLOCK, COSMIC ARK VENUS - OUTER SPACE

We exit KELDAN's residence to see a grimy, dense, concrete jungle that spans many floors. Each floor is crammed with apartments, shops, bars, and markets stacked on top of one another with neon signs indicating where things are (very Bladerunner/Cyberpunk). It is clearly not a very nice place to live.

We hear and see people shouting, crying out, and arguing. The council broadcast replays on a massive monitor.

We see a large crowd gathered in the concourse watching the broadcast unfold

KELDAN rushes down to see what's going on. He recognizes a familiar face and grabs his shoulder. He is about the same age as Keldan.

KELDAN

What the hell is going on?

NEIGHBOR 1

Didn't you see the broadcast?

KELDAN

Of course I did, I mean what the hell is going on down here?

NEIGHBOR 1

What do you think, it's the proposal! It feels like the whole ship is up in arms about it.

KELDAN

Good. That's good.

KELDAN pats him on the back before taking off.

KELDAN pushes through the crowd towards the front of the group, standing in front of the monitor. He stops and shouts before them, trying to get their attention.

KELDAN (CONT'D)
Ad domum nostram, humanitatem ut
unam.

ALL
Humanitatem ut unam.

Surprisingly, they quiet down, but it takes a second.

KELDAN
I did not expect that to work.

The group quiets down further, all wanting somebody to look too who may be able to calm them.

KELDAN (CONT'D)
Friends, neighbors, I know we all are upset. This proposal is preposterous and for what? To chase a fragment of a 'home' only to find what will inevitably another desolate rock. Clearly Admiral Marros has no regard for the Terra and what it stands for to us. The Terra is the only place on the fleet that gives us some joy and respite from this, shitty excuse for a home, and he wants to take that away?

At this point, AVERY begins to push through the crowd as well.

KELDAN (CONT'D)
What if that was us, what if the fate of Venus was on the line. I know we would not let that stand. I know we cannot go on living, if truly is the end of our journey, we will *not* go down without a fight.

Echoes of claps through the crowd, they seem to mostly be in agreement with Keldan.

KELDAN (CONT'D)
We go to the other sectors of Venus, gather them and visit the Terra, **stay** on the Terra. Let Captain Seph know that she's not alone. I have a feeling she needs out voices now more than ever.

[Note: I Really need to workshop the last bit of that scene, it doesn't quite land like I want it to.]

I think the speech itself is fine but the buildup to it falls a bit flat I think. Any feedback would be great!]

INT. CAPTAIN SEPH'S HOME, COSMIC ARK TERRA - NIGHT

We see CAPTAIN SEPH in her home office, it looks like a futuristic earth home. Seph looks at a tablet, sitting by a large window overlooking a forest, still dressed in her captains uniform. Some of the other cosmic arks can be seen in the night sky. There's a knock at the door. She takes a moment before responding

CAPTAIN SEPH

Come in.

DAMIEN SEPH, a tall male in his 40s, enters. He is dressed in leisurely clothes.

DAMIEN

Still up? I brought you some tea.

He walks over to her and sets it down on the coffee table beside her. She ignores it.

CAPTAIN SEPH

Did you tell Abi?

DAMIEN

No, she's asleep. I haven't told her yet. We should tell her in the morning though. She'll find out one way or another, better she hears it from you.

She nods.

CAPTAIN SEPH

Marros sent out the full proposal.

DAMIEN

And?

(MORE)

CAPTAIN SEPH

He plans to redistribute the water in the reservoirs across the other Arks, salvage all recyclable metals and circuitry in the hull to use them in manufacturing projects on Uranus, harvest all the equipment in the engine room as spare parts, take a number of biological samples for study and preservation on Saturn, and then just- leave the corpse behind.

DAMIEN

And that would be enough to sustain the fleet for three-hundred more years?

CAPTAIN SEPH

Apparently, it's not detailed how.

DAMIEN

Any idea how the other Arks are leaning?

CAPTAIN SEPH

Not a clue. Mars, Mercury, and Sol all seemed pretty adamant about the idea. I see no reason why Neptune and Uranus wouldn't follow suit at the promise of extra resources. That's five. I think we all know which way Marros would go in the event of a tie.

DAMIEN

What about Pluto? Surely you can count on Isobel's support given your history.

She shoots him a look, careful. He yields.

CAPTAIN SEPH

I didn't get a chance to catch up with her after the session, she had left before I did. I don't blame her, I'd want to get out of there as soon as possible. Heavens know I tried.

DAMIEN

And what about the other Arks?

CAPTAIN SEPH
I don't know Damien. I don't--

SEPH starts to break down, DAMIEN pulls her in tight, holding his wife. They pause, holding each other for a moment.

CAPTAIN SEPH (CONT'D)
I'm sorry. I didn't mean to--

DAMIEN
It's alright, I understand. Take
all the time you need.

SEPH collects herself, and takes a sip of the tea. She walks back over to the window, gazing out of it.

CAPTAIN SEPH
Venus maybe? Most of Terra's
visitors are families from there, I
saw many of them today. At least
they understand why the Terra was
built in the first place.

DAMIEN
I'm going to get some rest. You've
been up all night, you really
should too.

DAMIEN walks over to the window by her and runs his hand across her back, in attempt to comfort her.

CAPTAIN SEPH
I'll be in very soon.

DAMIEN gives her a skeptical look.

CAPTAIN SEPH (CONT'D)
I will.

She smiles, he smiles back and kissers her before he exits. CAPTAIN SEPH goes back to the large window, looking out over the Terra. After a few moments, she puts her hand on a panel by the window. It beeps, and the window goes dark (as if a blind immediately came down). She sits back down in a chair by the window, and pulls up the proposal again on her tablet.

EXT. OUTSIDE SEPH'S HOME, COSMIC ARK TERRA - MORNING

CAPTAIN SEPH sits in a chair outside of her house, still dressed in her captain's uniform from the previous day, she is again scrolling through her tablet.

INSERT TABLET SCREEN

We see a news headline along the lines of: "ADMIRAL MARROS SAVES HUMANITY WITH BOLD PROPOSAL." And then text and images from the council chamber under it.

BACK TO SCENE

The tablet screen flicks off as we hear footsteps behind CAPTAIN SEPH. ABIGAIL SEPH: A 10 year old girl exits the house and runs towards CAPTAIN SEPH and hugs her.

ABIGAIL
Why are you sad mom?

CAPTAIN SEPH
Now how did you come to that conclusion?

ABIGAIL
Dad told me.

Seph smiles a bit, she can't help but find this funny.

CAPTAIN SEPH
Well, he's not wrong. Take a seat Abi.

ABIGAIL sits on the grass beside CAPTAIN SEPH, she starts playing with it. CAPTAIN SEPH watches her for a while. Her smile fades before she speaks. ABIGAIL notices this, stops playing, and looks at CAPTAIN SEPH.

CAPTAIN SEPH (CONT'D)
We might have to move soon Abi.

ABIGAIL
Like onto a planet?!

CAPTAIN SEPH
No. We might have to move to another Ark.

ABIGAIL
But why? I like it here.

CAPTAIN SEPH
I know you do. I do too. We are very lucky to live here, perhaps the luckiest people alive. Not many in the whole history of our journey have had this privilege.

ABIGAIL
But why might we have to leave?

CAPTAIN SEPH
The Sol wants to salvage the Terra.

ABIGAIL
What does that mean?

CAPTAIN SEPH
Take it apart- and use it for other things.

ABIGAIL
Why? Terra is the best and most beautiful place on all of the Arks!

CAPTAIN SEPH
Because it may give us a better chance of finding a home.

ABIGAIL
But we already have a home!

CAPTAIN SEPH
Yes, the Terra is our home, but it's much more than that to others.

ABIGAIL
What is it?

CAPTAIN SEPH
Well it looks like someone needs to pay more attention to her history lessons. Maybe we'll take another family trip to Saturn soon.

CAPTAIN SEPH smiles. ABIGAIL looks guilty. CAPTAIN SEPH gives her a playful nudge.

CAPTAIN SEPH (CONT'D)
Long ago, before the Arks were created, all of humankind lived on a planet called Earth. A whole planet just as beautiful as Terra.

ABIGAIL
An entire planet?

CAPTAIN SEPH nods

ABIGAIL (CONT'D)
But why did they leave? What happened to it?

CAPTAIN SEPH

Well, its star- the sun, got too hot. They couldn't live there any more.

ABIGAIL

And then they built the arks and left?

CAPTAIN SEPH

Yes, all of them named after another planet, but the Terra was a special one.

ABIGAIL

Because the planet was named Earth.

CAPTAIN SEPH

Yes! It reminds us of humanity's original home, so as we search for a new one among all the stars--

CAPTAIN SEPH gestures to the sky

CAPTAIN SEPH (CONT'D)

The Terra both allows us to remember the home we left behind and reminds us of what we are searching for. So- when things seem the darkest, and the future is scary, and uncertain, the Terra helps all of us remember what awaits us once our long journey is finally over.

ABIGAIL

Why would anyone want to take that away?

CAPTAIN SEPH

I don't know Abi. That's what your mom is trying to stop.

ABIGAIL

I hope you do mom.

ABIGAIL hugs her mother tightly. They sit in this moment for a while.

CAPTAIN SEPH looks at the environment around her.

CAPTAIN SEPH

Now, I've got to get down to the bridge.

(MORE)

CAPTAIN SEPH (CONT'D)
Have a nice day Abi, tell your dad
to teach you some more history.

ABIGAIL nods, then runs inside. CAPTAIN SEPH follows her inside.

ABIGAIL runs upstairs.

CAPTAIN SEPH places her hand on a panel by the door, it beeps, then slides open revealing an elevator. She steps inside.

Inside the elevator, she straightens her uniform and her shoulders stiffen as the kindly demeanor she put on for her family quickly fades.

INT. COSMIC ARK TERRA BRIDGE - OUTER SPACE

SEPH exits the elevator to the bridge. It looks very practical, unlike the rest of the Terra. There are lots of well worn consoles with screens and flashing buttons but it does look better than what we've seen aboard the Venus.

The ADVISORS sit at the consoles and stand and bow when CAPTAIN SEPH enters. COMM. OFFICER SMITH and COMMANDER CORWIN are also here. COMMANDER CORWIN sits in what appears to be the captain's chair while COMM. OFFICER SMITH types at a computer.

CAPTAIN SEPH
Good morning all, how are things
looking this morning.

COMMANDER CORWIN
Besides the obvious, everything is
well down here captain, all systems
are functioning as normal.

COMMANDER CORWIN yields the captain's chair to CAPTAIN SEPH. There's a part of her that feels relieved to get back into her usual routine.

CAPTAIN SEPH
Officer Smith, have we received any
communications from the other arks.

COMM. OFFICER SMITH
None ma'am.

CAPTAIN SEPH
None?

OFFICER SMITH shakes his head.

COMM. OFFICER SMITH
There are several from press
outlets asking what our official
stance on the vote is, but none
from the officers of the other
arks.

He pauses

COMM. OFFICER SMITH (CONT'D)
What is our official stance ma'am?

A long pause, everyone in the bridge goes silent and turns
towards CAPTAIN SEPH

CAPTAIN SEPH
I'm sorry?

COMM. OFFICER SMITH
The Terra's official stance on the
admiral's proposal.

This makes CAPTAIN SEPH visibly annoyed. She walks over
towards OFFICER SMITH.

CAPTAIN SEPH
The Terra's official stance is
this: "Anyone who supports this
proposal is in direct opposition to
the mission of our the Last
Terrans, our ancestors. You have
lost sight of everything our
thousand-year plight has been for."
That is all officer.

COMMANDER CORWIN
Captain, with all due respect, if
the chances of finding a habitable
planet on the next generational
horizon are as slim as they say
they are, you must admit the
Admiral's proposal does have some
merit.

CAPTAIN SEPH clenches her fist and swallows her next words.
She looks towards Commander Corwin.

Then she looks toward her vacant captains chair. She stares
at it for a while, formulating her response.

CAPTAIN SEPH
As much as I hate to admit it
Commander-- I do.
(MORE)

CAPTAIN SEPH (CONT'D)
I understand the logic behind the
Admiral's proposal.

There is a silence throughout the bridge.

CAPTAIN SEPH (CONT'D)
But it's fear, not hope, that
drives it, and I cannot in good
conscious accept that outcome. The
Terra is more than a space where
anyone can come to find a moments
reprieve from their toil aboard the
other arks --no. It's a monument to
everything the Terrans
accomplished, to all they
sacrificed, and to all that we one
day can--

She pauses, bites her tongue.

CAPTAIN SEPH (CONT'D)
To all that we one day *will* be.

There is a beep of a technological device from COMM. OFFICER
SMITH's computer. He was recording everything she said.

COMM. OFFICER SMITH
There's your official statement.

CAPTAIN SEPH smiles.

CAPTAIN SEPH
I knew you'd get the hang of the
job.

There is a beep from a machine by COMMANDER CORWIN. There is
a silence as the crew waits.

COMMANDER CORWIN
Captain, multiple transport crafts
from the Cosmic Ark Venus have
requested priority docking
permission aboard Terra within the
next few hours, there's also a
message from Captain Dione of the
Cosmic Ark Venus. Sounds like
they're with us.

CAPTAIN SEPH takes a deep breath, then sits back down in the
captains chair, looking out the main window.

EXT. OUTER SPACE

We follow CAPTAIN SEPH's gaze outside the window. We see multiple small spacecraft travelling towards the terra in the foreground, and the golden fuselage of the Cosmic Ark Sol in the background.

INT. COSMIC ARK SOL BRIDGE - OUTER SPACE

ADMIRAL MARROS stands looking out of a large gold adorned window with a hand on his throne-like captain's chair.

A hologram of the Cosmic Ark Terra hovers in the center of this chamber. Two SOL OFFICERS stand by the doorway.

MARROS turns and looks at the hologram, studying it.

SOL OFFICER (O.S)
Captain Farren of the Cosmic Ark
Mercury is here to see you sir.

ADMIRAL MARROS
Send him in.

The door slides open as the two SOL OFFICERS step aside. CAPTAIN FARREN enters, the two officers bow.

Captain Farren approaches Admiral Marros and bows.

CAPTAIN FARREN
Sir, I just spoke with CAPTAIN MARS
and CAPTAIN URANUS, they're firmly
in support of your proposal.

ADMIRAL MARROS
And where do you stand Captain?

CAPTAIN FARREN
I'm sorry sir?

ADMIRAL MARROS
Surely you have a stance on my
proposal, yes?

CAPTAIN FARREN
Of course I support it Admiral, I-

He catches his mistake. Admiral Marros nods.

ADMIRAL MARROS
This isn't my proposal, captain.
It's ours. Our proposal that will
save the fleet.

(Beat)

CAPTAIN FARREN
Or tear it apart. And when it does,
Admiral, will you be the one to
take the fall for that?

Marros pauses. He didn't expect this sort of pushback. He takes another beat.

Admiral Marros walks towards Captain Farren, cutting through the hologram of the Terra, it warps and shimmers for a moment.

ADMIRAL MARROS
For a time it may. But when the
generations after us see the
sacrifices we made for them-- what
we gave up just so they could live
to see another horizon, they will
keep going, and the fleet will
survive.

CAPTAIN FARREN
But at the cost of our mission? Of
humanity's chance at a home, a real
home?

ADMIRAL MARROS
Our mission is slipping away from
us, Captain. You've seen the signs,
hell, your officers are the ones
who told me.

Farren's guard drops, this resonates with him.

ADMIRAL MARROS (CONT'D)
The arks are our home now, and the
arks must survive. Our plan for
Terra is the first step, but
certainly not the last. I need to
know that I have your support
moving forwards.

Farren acknowledges, and drops his head, regretting how he spoke out of turn.

CAPTAIN FARREN
Of course, Admiral.

ADMIRAL MARROS
Good.

MARROS walks back over to the hologram of the Terra. He waves his hand and suddenly the image shifts to display the other Cosmic Arks. The Sol is in the center with the other nine around it in a circular pattern.

The Sol is already lit up green. MARROS taps the icons for the Cosmic Arks Uranus, Mars, and Mercury. They all turn green. The Terra is lit up red.

MARROS and FARREN both look at the arks lit up green.

CAPTAIN FARREN

That's four, we just need one more to force a tie.

ADMIRAL MARROS

That's the minimum, though I would prefer not to go that route if we can avoid it. It's important the arks are unified in this. Best they hold the majority, without my needing to break the stalemate.

CAPTAIN FARREN

Neptune is a safe bet, our plan gives them a great influx of materials, far more than we could extract in any single harvesting operation, not to mention they're already refined.

ADMIRAL MARROS

We won't be able to count on Venus or Saturn. The people of Venus spend far more time on Terra than any other ark, and Saturn greatly enjoys having access to the atrium for research. We would of course give them any needed samples for preservation, but they won't stand to see Terra go, regardless of the logic against.

CAPTAIN FARREN

That would leave...

Captain Farren waves his hand over the model of the arks, now only Pluto and Jupiter are displayed. Jupiter is by far the largest of the arks.

CAPTAIN FARREN (CONT'D)

The battery and the graveyard.

Admiral Marros gives him a glare.

ADMIRAL MARROS
Careful. Pluto bears the weight of
the wake Jupiter fuels across the
stars. The ox and the yoke--
Captain.

Admiral Marros does a gesture to single out the image of
Cosmic Ark Pluto in the hologram.

Captain Farren is briefly taken aback by something Marros
said.

CAPTAIN FARREN
I didn't realize you kept to the
Old Faith Admiral.

ADMIRAL MARROS
The Old Faith has many stories that
all would benefit from learning,
but I digress. Your thoughts?

Marros gestures to the hologram. Captain Farren examines the
model of the Cosmic Ark Pluto

CAPTAIN FARREN
Pluto? Winter and Seph studied
together on Saturn for years,
there's not a path where they don't
vote together.

ADMIRAL MARROS
Indeed, but should the proposal go
through it would make Pluto's load
much lighter, and I'm not sure how
much more weight the yoke can bear.

They both stare intently at the hologram of the Cosmic Ark
Pluto

INT. COSMIC ARK TERRA BRIDGE - OUTER SPACE

We see CAPTAIN SEPH and her OFFICERS busily working and
talking with each other throughout the bridge. They all move
with purpose.

Seph makes her way over to COMM. OFFICER SMITH who is typing
anxiously at a computer terminal. She looks over his
shoulder.

CAPTAIN SEPH
More than you signed up for
officer?

COMM. OFFICER SMITH
Yes ma'am. I think I've fielded
more conversations today than I
have in my month working here so
far.

CAPTAIN SEPH
Care for some more?

He sighs, she smiles.

CAPTAIN SEPH (CONT'D)
Please let Captain Dione know that
I'll join her in the boreal forest
biome of the atrium shortly. I look
like shit and I need to make myself
somewhat presentable.

He starts typing, Seph begins walking away then quickly turns
back.

CAPTAIN SEPH (CONT'D)
Don't tell her that last part.

He nods and gets to work.

Captain Seph crosses back to the captains chair where
COMMANDER CORWIN currently sits.

COMMANDER CORWIN
Go, Captain. I've got it in
control.

CAPTAIN SEPH
Thank you Commander, you have the
helm.

Captain Seph exits the bridge.

INT. CAPTAIN SEPH'S HOME, COSMIC ARK TERRA - MORNING

BEGIN MONTAGE:

CAPTAIN SEPH tries to decompress in a small but tiled shower
(censored, trying to keep it PG-13 here). There's lots of
steam. She takes her time feeling the hot water fall on her
face, she seems to be deep in thought.

Out of the shower, she now looks in a bathroom mirror. The
bathroom is neatly kept and rather nice looking. She again
takes her time, mostly looking in the mirror, she notices the
large bags under her eyes.

In her bedroom, she opens her closet and retrieves a new captains uniform. There are many in there, all with dark green cloaks. Some are more functional, while others are more decorative in there. The one she grabs looks more functional than the previous one she had on, but cleaner and fresher.

Now outside, once more dressed in her captains uniform, she walks through a garden of sorts outside her house. She walks by a strawberry bush, stops, and picks a few, putting them in a smooth plastic basket.

ABIGAIL SEPH runs out and joins her in the garden picking berries. She picks a strawberry herself and holds it up to her mother, as if asking for permission. Seph hesitates for a moment, then smiles and nods. Abigail smiles.

Captain Seph continues past the garden, out into the larger Cosmic Ark Terra Atrium, basket of berries in hand.

END MONTAGE

EXT. COSMIC ARK TERRA ATRIUM - MORNING

CAPTAIN SEPH walks along a paved path through a forest of tall cedar, spruce, and pine trees. Rocks and moss are strewn across the ground. We hear the BABBLING OF A STREAM.

Eventually, she reaches a clearing in with a few benches in it. CAPTAIN DIONE, a woman in her late 60s, clearly a seasoned captain, and dressed in a similar white captains uniform with a rose gold cloak, sits at the center.

Dione stands and bows as Seph approaches. Seph returns the bow.

CAPTAIN DIONE

Ad domum nostram, humanitatem ut unam.

CAPTAIN SEPH

Humanitatem ut unam. I am very happy to see you Captain, thank you so much for taking your time to come here.

CAPTAIN DIONE

I should be the one thanking you, I've never seen my crew more united around a single cause.

CAPTAIN SEPH

I wish it were around a lighter one.

CAPTAIN DIONE

Captain, I've been in command of Venus longer than you have been alive, to see them so united about a cause --any cause-- is something to be proud of. Captain Almec would.

Captain Seph smiles, this means a great deal to her.

CAPTAIN DIONE (CONT'D)

Though as we all saw in the council chamber, you certainly inherited his temper. That's something to work on.

CAPTAIN SEPH

I know I shouldn't speak out of turn but--

CAPTAIN DIONE

You don't need to explain yourself to me. He may be the highest ranking member of humanity, but Marros had no right to disclose that in the manner he did.

CAPTAIN SEPH

It was still wrong of me to erupt in the chamber like that, but I know you didn't come all the way here to reprimand me.

Captain Dione reciprocates with a scoff and a smirk.

CAPTAIN DIONE

No. As I said, your speech resonated with my crew and in effect they rallied around your cause.

Captain Dione pauses and takes in the environment around her. The stream babbles as wind gently brushes through the trees around them. Seph shivers a bit, but Dione welcomes the cool breeze.

CAPTAIN DIONE (CONT'D)

Unfortunately, they have no say in the fate of the Terra, as is the way the last Terrans set for us, but *I* do.

CAPTAIN SEPH

And where do you stand on the
Admiral's proposal?

CAPTAIN DIONE

While I don't think that this is
the proper first step, I see the
reasoning behind the proposal. I am
terrified, as should you be, as
should everyone be.

Seph sinks, but not quite disheartened.

CAPTAIN DIONE (CONT'D)

But I stand with my crew. They
deserve a voice in this matter,
even more so than I.

Seph breathes a sigh of relief.

CAPTAIN DIONE (CONT'D)

Venus is with you, Captain Seph,
and I want to find a path forward--
together.

CAPTAIN SEPH

Thank you, Captain Dione.

We see the two seated on the rectangular bench, framed in the
middle of the forest, and dominated by the northern landscape
around them. Seph reaches down to the basket on the ground
besides her.

CAPTAIN SEPH (CONT'D)

Here, these are for you.

Captain Dione takes the basket and opens it. She takes out a
strawberry and inspects it. She chuckles, almost surprised.

CAPTAIN DIONE

The real thing, huh?

We see both of them in the forest again, seph nods.

Dione takes a bite of the strawberry. The red juice runs down
her chin, it kind of looks like Denethor eating that tomato
in lord of the rings, but like, not disgusting and it's a
happy moment. Dione is almost ecstatic.

CAPTAIN DIONE (CONT'D)

And to think--

She takes her hand and rubs the juice off her lips, then looks at the strawberry remnants in her hand, and waves it around.

CAPTAIN DIONE (CONT'D)
This is what they would leave
behind. Thank you, Captain Seph,
this is a great gift.

CAPTAIN SEPH
You're very welcome, it's the least
I could do.

CAPTAIN DIONE
Now, some of my overseers have
accompanied me to Terra, I believe
they'd like a word with you.

CAPTAIN SEPH
Of course, I'd be happy to meet
with them.

The two get up and begin walking through the Terra.

They follow a stream, covered with mossy stones and lined
with tall coniferous trees.

Eventually, they approach a small lake where KELDAN and some
other OVERSEERS sit by the lake. The overseers are mostly
They notice the captains approach, stand, and bow.

Captain Seph notices Keldan and smiles at him.

CAPTAIN SEPH (CONT'D)
Didn't think you'd be back on the
Terra so soon did you?

KELDAN
Neither did I ma'am.

CAPTAIN DIONE
You two know each other?

CAPTAIN SEPH
We met briefly just yesterday
morning.

CAPTAIN DIONE
Then I suppose an introduction is
in order. Captain Seph, these are
some of my Overseers. They each
look over one of the many residence
blocks on Venus and see to the
daily concerns of her citizens.

CAPTAIN SEPH

Well, I can imagine the last twenty four hours have been a lot, thank you all for what you do.

OVERSEER 1

Indeed, Captain Seph, many in my block care deeply about the Terra, it's all they do in their leisure time.

Seph nods and smiles, appreciating the compliment, but seems a tad disheartened.

KELDAN

Captain, when my block watched the session broadcast they were scared, I worry how the rest of the fleet will react, but whatever I can do to help, we can.

This picks up Seph's spirits a little bit, she welcomes the help.

CAPTAIN SEPH

Right, thank you all for being here. As Captain Dione showed me, you all are very passionate about the Terra, and I am very thankful for that. It's clear the Terra means so much to you all, as it does to me, and many others. I know the future is uncertain, which is why we need to find a path forward, together.

She pauses, looking at the group.

CAPTAIN SEPH (CONT'D)

If you are all willing to help, we need your voice to be heard across all the arks, as we need to convince their captains, just as how you all did with Captain Dione.

KELDAN

I've spoken to many friends on Saturn, they want nothing more than to study and preserve the complimented eco system aboard the Terra, it grounds them, reminds them of what we lost.

Captain Seph smiles at Keldan, looks at Captain Dione, than back at the rest of the group.

CAPTAIN SEPH

And we'll need that knowledge once our mission is complete, Keldan, that sounds like a good place to start.

INT. COSMIC ARK SATURN ARCHIVE - OUTER SPACE